

evening

The Voice Express

The Truth Takes Time. page

POLITICS

Sab Kuch Yaad Rakha Jayega

Six years after police entered Jamia Millia Islamia's campus without notice, vandalized the library, and attacked students, unwittingly triggering the historic Shaheen Bagh movement against CAA-NRC, law student and activist Anjan Azad bears testimony to what happened that December, and what has not changed since.

BY ANJAN AZAD



Photo: Anjan Azad

As history is rewritten, no recent date haunts those who rewrite it more than 15th December 2019, when police entered campus without administrative permissions or notice, vandalized the library, brutally attacked students and even opened fire in front of the campus gates. For the students of Jamia, 15th December cannot be erased, no matter how hard the fascists try.

6 years later, the discriminatory CAA is still in place, and the NCR project has accelerated to full force with the Act's implementation, and through the backdoors with the enforcement of Special Intensive Revisions of voter rolls. Anjan also reveals how the university's own administrative and academic resources have been weaponised against students in an attempt to categorically erase dissent from Jamia's campus space.

15th December 2025, New Delhi: While the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) and its many subsidiaries advance their Hindutva political offensive, history has been a crucial arena of their attack. We can see that they are rewriting every part of history, starting from the period of the Harappan Civilization, running through the pre-vedic, later vedic, medieval, British and post-British periods, to even the most recent decades. The changes in NCERT textbooks, state text-books, bans on books on Kashmir etc., are some of the examples of this project of history rewriting.

As history is rewritten, no recent date haunts those who rewrite it more than 15th December 2019, a memory they want erased. Every year, the students of Jamia Millia Islamia observe this date as 'Jamia Resistance Day'.

On this 15th December, Jamia's own black day of police brutality completes its 6 years. 15th December, 2019, when police entered campus without administrative permissions or notice, vandalized the library, brutally attacked students and even opened fire in front of the campus gates.

It was here that the historical people's upsurge, the movement against the Citizenship (Amendment) Act, the National Register of Citizens, and the National Population Register now known as the movement against CAA-NRC-NPR stood up at Shaheen Bagh, with echoes of the outrage ringing across the whole country.

The Movement

On 11th December, 2019, the Citizenship (Amendment) Bill was passed in the Rajya Sabha; the following day, on 12th December, with the assent of the President of India, Bill became Act, and the notorious CAA was born.

The CAA provided Indian citizenship to Hindus, Parsis, Sikhs, Buddhists, Jains and Christians who escaped to India from religious persecution in Muslim-majority Afghanistan, Bangladesh and Pakistan before December 31st, 2014. The RSS propaganda machine, while on one hand said, "We are not snatching anyone's citizenship, we are just providing," on the other through RSS-BJP leaders gave an open call to kick out those, "Muslims who came from outside, illegally."

The Act, while notorious for destroying the basic structure of the constitution by making religion a basis for citizenship, was deliberately silent on identities like those of Rohingya Muslims and Tamils, who came to India as a result of religious and linguistic persecution in Myanmar and Sri Lanka respectively, and so too on many others. What of those who are not able to prove their citizenship, even after being born and raised up in India? The Assam experience with regards to NRC itself proved how harsh the reality was, cutting across all religions.

In simple terms, CAA was a weapon for RSS to spread Islamophobia and transform India into the fascist, fantastical 'Hindu Rashtra': an organized massacre of the oppressed people of India.

The Citizenship (Amendment) Bill itself was vehemently opposed by the people: protests that began in Assam on the 4th of December, the day the Bill was introduced, and soon spread across the North-Eastern corridor, through Meghalaya, Arunachal, and Tripura; quickly making their way to the national capital.

The Repression

A day after the Bill was passed in the Upper-House of the Parliament, a peaceful protest-march was planned by the students of Jamia to Jantar Mantar from the campus. Before the march even began, though, on the 13th of December, students were preemptively stopped by the police and brutally beaten up, with at least 50 students being extrajudicially detained. At Jantar Mantar, the nearest metro stations at Janpath and Patel Chowk were shut down for over ten hours to prevent any possibility of assembly. The march was postponed to 15th December.

On the 15th, the situation escalated to an extreme level: the campus was attacked and the library was vandalized by the police and paramilitary forces. Caught on widely circulated CCTV footage, uniformed and ununiformed police entered the Central Library and assaulted those studying; not even those inside toilets and washrooms were spared. In response, the whole campus came out onto the streets to resist the attack and raise the slogan to repeal CAA-NRC-NPR.

The Shaheen Bagh movement against CAA-NRC-NPR which started in December 2019, continued till March 2020, when a nationwide lockdown was declared under COVID-19. This was a good opportunity for the fascists to crush the movement under the guise of the pandemic. A lot of students were charged with UAPA and were incarcerated for what are now going to be over 6 years during the anti-CAA-NRC movement.

This was especially so in North-East Delhi, where the Delhi Pogrom took place in February 2020. Umar Khalid, Sharjeel Imam, Meeran Haider, Gulfisha Fatima, Shifa-ur-Rehman etc. are all still in jail, as trial prisoners for half a decade, under the draconian, anti-people, undemocratic UAPA.

Meanwhile, the thirst of the fascists in sucking the blood of muslims is not yet over. After more than 4 years of attempts to implement the CAA through backdoors, the government managed to implement it in March, 2024, during the Ramzan month, with the release of the CAA Rules.

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University and the State

While the saga of fascist onslaught on people continues and intensifies, 15th December can be a spark, once again, for a united resistance. But the fascists in power do not want that to happen. Thus, their agenda is clear: Erase 15th December from history. That's part of the broader agenda of curbing every possibility to develop a massive upsurge.

In Jamia, democratic spaces are shrinking day by day, with zero tolerance to any voice of dissent. This is reflected in the recent series of actions taken by the Jamia Administration:

Mazhar Asif, a person highly loyal to the Sangh Parivar, and a drafting committee member of the saffron National Education Policy, 2020, was appointed Vice Chancellor of Jamia in November 2024. Within a month, prior to that year's Resistance's Day, a PhD Scholar named Alfauz was forced to deregister from his PhD. He was a prominent activist in Jamia.

The administration had thought that Alfauz's rustication would help in creating fear in the students, so that a further gathering would be cancelled altogether. Despite this, various organizations gave the call for observing Jamia's Resistance Day. Seeing this, on the 15th of December, 2024, the entire university was closed under the pretense of maintenance, maintenance that predictably never took place .

Despite this , students gathered on both the 15th and the 16th of December. The very next morning, Show Cause notices were liberally distributed to 4 students: Saurabh, a PhD scholar of the Hindi department, and General Secretary of All India Student's Association (AISA); Jyoti, another Hindi PhD scholar and a member of Dayar-I-Shauq Students' Charter (DISSC); Fuzail, a BTech student, and me.

In February, Saurabh and Jyoti were called to appear before the Disciplinary Committee (DC) for initiating Disciplinary Proceedings against them. Thus, Jamia witnessed another mass movement: this time, to Reclaim Campus Democracy . The main demands were to repeal Show Cause notices, DC notices and the notorious Office Memorandum that put a blanket ban on protests and political gatherings. 4 days of continuous sit-in protest then were followed by a massive crackdown: Police detentions, FIRs, suspensions, breach of privacy and many other means to witch-hunt students.

Onward

Ironically, silencing dissent in Jamia isn't quite possible, simply because dissent is the idea of Jamia. There is no Jamia without dissent.

After the revocation of our suspensions, we still continued to raise issues and politicize students. Last month, Saurabh got campus banned till the end of his PhD for organizing a march in remembrance of the Batla House False Encounter. But targeting people and taking action against them won't stop them from continuing to resist: that is the collective determination of the students of Jamia.

On the eve of the 6th anniversary of the open terrorist attack by the police and other paramilitary forces on Jamia, not just the memories of repression, but also the repression itself can be seen continuing in a sinister form. The implementation of CAA & NRC, incarceration of anti-CAA fighters, curbs on democratic spaces all over the country and Jamia Millia Islamia through institutions like bureaucracy and military forces, tagging Jamia as “ anti-national ” etc., continue liberally as part of the incumbent government's fascist tactics.

That is why, political tasks in front of us are multiple. The demand for democratic spaces in educational institutions, the struggle to repeal UAPA and release all political prisoners, to repeal CAA-NRC-NPR and ultimately, to overthrow fascists from power are all part of these political tasks, the very ones that Shaheen Bagh once did and now continues to signify. 15th December is not a ritual but Jamia's collective memory of resistance; a reiteration of 2019. Our memories can't be snatched away from us, and the Resistance Days shall keep on coming, year after year.

One day, 15th December will reemerge as a massive upsurge. No matter how hard the fascists try to erase history, our message to them is clear: Sab yaad rakha jayega. Sab kuch yaad rakha jayega . (Everything will be remembered. Every last thing will be remembered.)



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